



BEFORE

Japan's history reveals that it has rarely been at peace. For centuries, the Imperial court and the warrior classes wrestled for control.

REUNIFICATION OF JAPAN

From the mid-15th to late 16th centuries, Japan was riven by civil wars, and by 1560 a handful of warring families vied for supremacy << 168–69. The emperor remained as a figurehead, without power, and three outstanding leaders:

TOKUGAWA IEYASU



Oda Nobunaga, Toyotomi Hideyoshi, and Tokugawa Ieyasu displayed superior military tactics and shocking acts of brutality to unify Japan. Ieyasu was made a shogun in 1603, and was recognized as the greatest power in the land.

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TOKUGAWA RULE

With Japan reunified, Ieyasu's aim was to maintain control. All foreign influences were discouraged, and from 1635 Japanese subjects were unable to leave Japan—those Japanese who were overseas at the time were

refused reentry on pain of death. Christianity was banned, and foreign merchants and missionaries expelled. With its borders closed, contact with outsiders could be strictly regulated by the shogun << 242–43.

A CLOSED COUNTRY

For two centuries, descendants of the Tokugawa shoguns kept the peace, and the population prospered. But from the early 19th century, environmental and political troubles caused the shoguns' grip on power to slip. Famine and earthquakes caused thousands of deaths, trade within Japan widened the gap between rich and poor, and foreigners sailed into Japanese waters.

Japan's development from a land of feudal lords into a world power began in the 19th century. During the reunification of Japan (see BEFORE), the country was closed to foreign visitors and trade, but in 1853 the American government sent Commodore Matthew Perry to Edo (Tokyo) in command of four warships. Perry demanded the opening of Japanese ports for trade, making it clear he would return. Resistance seemed futile in the face of superior naval power. In 1854, Perry returned with an even larger fleet, and the shogunate (military rulers) signed the Treaty of Kanagawa. Japan was forced to open its borders.

Westernizing society

Similar treaties with Britain, France, Russia, and the Netherlands followed. They too were successful in demanding rights to trade, and Japan gradually lost control over its own customs duties. The Japanese people viewed these unequal treaties as humiliating, and a series of rebellions brought nearly 700 years of shogunate rule to an end. Following the Meiji Restoration (see right), the

Rising Sun

The "Land of the Rising Sun," as it is known to most Japanese, has had a turbulent history. For centuries it was a society ruled by fierce warlords, and for over 200 years it was closed to the rest of the world. Ambitious and industrious Japan quickly caught up with the West, but success came at a heavy price.

